Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Gene Bertoncini

Gene Bertoncini was born in New York City on April 6, 1937 and began playing the electric guitar at age seven. During his career he has performed with some of the greatest soloists in jazz and as part of the Tonight Show and Merv Griffin orchestras. He currently enjoys performing as a solo guitarist and with his musical partner, bassist Michael Moore.

Gene was interviewed in New York City on January 13, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in New York City for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive at the IAJE festival. I'm pleased to have Gene Bertoncini for my guest this morning. And I think we're both a little dazed by all the music and the activity going on.

GB: It's a tremendous event. I think there are about seven thousand people here.

MR: It's amazing to watch the veteran musicians especially, try to walk down the hall. There are so many people you run into and you have to have a conversation.

GB: You know just getting here was pretty hard. I ran into Nick Brignola and Sid Jacobs and music publishers, and Loren Treola and Booker, and I could go on and on, just getting from the lobby, which is not that crowded at this hour. This is four o'clock in the morning? What time is it now?

MR: Don't remind me.

GB: And it's nice though. It's wonderful to be — also for me to be recognized. I guess at 63 I'm finally getting to be a bit of a known entity in the jazz world, in the guitar world. So I'm happy about that.

MR: Did it seem like that took a long time?

GB: Yeah, in a way. But in retrospect it happened so fast. I just had breakfast with two buddies of mine, my roommate from college and my good friend. And this was in 1956 we were in school together, we started school together. And it just seemed like yesterday. And here we are talking and hugging each other.

MR: Right. I see from a few notes that I found that you started pretty early on as a guitar player.

GB: Yeah. I was seven.

MR: You didn't start with something else and go to the guitar?

GB: Yeah, my dad had a guitar around the house. He was from Italy and he used to sing Italian folk songs. And it was always around and I just took to it. Well I just considered that a great gift you know. I don't quite understand that either.

MR: Italian heritage is pretty strong in music, isn't it? The family, and the music in the house.

GB: Yeah, it is. If you go to Italy and the history of Italy I think, with the operas, the Puccini and people like Verdi and especially when my mother and father were born in a region called Emilia Romagna, where Parma is, where my mother's home town is, and my father was next door. And Parma was where Giuseppe Verdi and — this famous opera house in Parma.

MR: You want to stop for a moment?

GB: Yeah. I was just on a great thought man.

MR: Well let me ask the question again and we'll like—

GB: I was on a roll.

MR: You want something to drink?

GB: Maybe the apple juice caused the problem. Do you have any grappa? Like fire water. In Italy — we're on Italy now so—

MR: Actually we have something in the bar.

GB: No that's okay. I think I'm okay.

MR: Okay. Yeah, we were talking about—

GB: Parma is where Giuseppe Verdi was born and there is this famous Parma Opera House and it's a very musical city. But I imagine there are musical cities everyplace in Europe. But it seems like accordion and guitar are pretty prominent in Italian homes and for that matter in Polish homes too. But my dad always — Christmas in our house, where everybody came because that's where my brother played accordion and I played guitar and the Italian folks would sing. So music was a great gift from my family and from God I guess.

MR: I see you were on television at age sixteen.

GB: Yeah. Earlier than that actually.

MR: Really?

GB: A children's hour. Every Sunday morning. Once in a while my brother and I would get asked to play and accompany some children — not that I wasn't — and it was great. And I wandered next door one day and I saw this great guitar playing in a studio. This was the NBC studios. I walked up to him with my little cowboy hat on and I said I'd like to play for him. Well he asked me — well he asked me to play. It was Johnny Smith. And I played my version of "Honeysuckle Rose" and then after that whenever I did a show I would go next door and Johnny would give me a lesson.

MR: Oh, neat.

GB: And then after a while we became good friends. So I got off to a great start. It was him.

MR: How did the jazz creep into your consciousness?

GB: You know I can remember about that age, a little earlier, around that time, I would just go to the radio shows. And there were times that I knew that Benny Goodman was playing

on the radio. And I was simply drawn to that music. And I just — I remember I couldn't wait for that show to go on and just, instead of "Baby Snookes," you know those shows in those days were just — before your time — before everybody's time. And "Fibber McGee and Molly" and those radio shows, I used to listen to the live broadcasts and stuff like that. And that too, I don't quite understand why you know? Why that happens, and why you are drawn to a particular work or a particular art, except that I just consider it all a gift. And the gift of being drawn to the music, the gift of wanting to learn that music, the gift of an instrument, of a particular instrument, it's all something that we don't have choices really. We do make a choice but the choice is something we really want. And why we desire those things is a big mystery. I often get irritated at people who think they've created their own gift.

MR: Oh no kidding.

GB: Yeah. You know they feel like it's all them, instead of recognizing the fact that it's really something else at play.

MR: Is it – the gift that's given to you, but then you have an option perhaps. Like what are you going to do with it.

GB: Right. That too. Then I guess you can take some credit for that, for the pursuit of that gift. But also there are so many circumstances in life that help you along the way. Having a good set of parents or an older brother who was always supportive and people along the way who have always applauded and encouraged me. And some people aren't that fortunate. And they come out great anyway. That's an amazing thing. People that have hardships like people growing up in Russia who had to learn jazz from listening to the radio. And didn't have a night club to play in or a place to have a jam session. They've just got to do it all on their own. I know a great couple of Russian musicians and Polish musicians that are just amazing.

MR: You had other interests besides music too, didn't you? Growing up?

GB: Yeah. I have — I like girls.

MR: Okay, well that's good.

GB: I knew that's what you were referring to. No I have a degree in architecture. I fell in love with architecture. I used to copy the plans out of the *New York Times* Sunday real estate section. And I did some work in construction. My dad always — he rebuilt two homes when we were growing up and so I was always like kind of interested in the building stuff. I always thought I might be in that area. And my high school advisor said — well when I told him I liked, I also liked drafting. In those days we actually drew with pencils and T-squares. I was really upset to visit the Frank Lloyd Wright office and school in Taliesin Arizona and to see that everything was computer. Everything. They don't use — maybe if you're lucky they might do a sketch for you. But in those days, and that was

such — to have that white piece of paper and the tools to draw with, to make lines. That was very nice. I enjoyed that a lot. I still would enjoy that too.

MR: Do you think that had any effect on — that interest — in the way you play?

GB: Yeah. Yeah I do. I like to plan stuff. I like to — when I play a piece of music I usually arrange it and I usually think of a concept for it, and have an area where there's improvisation. I like to think of the guitar as my little orchestra, or a big band. And I do arrangements for my big band. And I play them and I work out fairly complicated things. I was fortunate in that I fell in love with the music of — aside from jazz players — the music of Julian Bream, a great English guitarist and I heard his interpretation of the Ravel "Pavanne" and the amazing orchestra qualities that the guitar has. And so it's really worth the effort of trying to arrange things for the guitar. So in that sense, the way an architect would present a set of plans or a colored drawing of a building to a client, I think I do the same with the music in a concert. I like to present a finished set of plans to an audience. But in the middle of it is this, just as in a big band, I went to hear Maria Schneider's band the other night, and I heard her wonderful arrangements, and she plays, the band plays those arrangements. She writes new ones, but they play those arrangements as is, and the difference every night is the spirit of the evening, whatever happens and the sections where the guys get a chance to improvise. And that's what I feel about the guitar, I could do. And I don't feel like I'm cheating by playing the same arrangements. Of course, every night there's some things you do off the top of your head, which you can't really do with a big band.

MR: That's right. It gets a little unwieldy.

GB: Yeah.

MR: Well I can tell that kind of thinking that you have, especially when I listen to your duo work with Michael Moore.

GB: Yeah.

MR: You guys seem to have like minds. He seems to be a perfect guy for you to —

GB: Yeah, we have another magical kind of gift, the rapport. We're doing a couple of things together coming up. We haven't done as much in the past few years. Because I've embarked on a bit of a solo thing, and he was out of the country for a while. But you know, when we get back together after maybe having not played for a couple of years and it's just like yesterday. It's like we have this big concert coming up soon at the Museum of Art in Boston, which is a nice thing.

MR: Yeah, I'll bet your music would sound great in an art museum.

GB: Yeah.

MR: 1961 I see you did some work with a number of guys, Buddy Rich.

GB: Right.

MR: And Sam Most, that's a name I like to see.

GB: Yeah. Sam was, well when I got out of school, one of the first things I did after graduating from architecture was get a job in a club in the Bronx, a little bar and grill called the Capri. And the trio was Mike Mainieri on vibes and a then bass player named Johnny Morris, who is also a wonderful pianist. And we put together a lot of things. Mike and I got together and rehearsed a lot of complicated lines, somewhat like Red Norvo and Tal Farlow years before. And so we had these wonderful arrangements. And we played them whenever we could and eventually Mike got the job with Buddy Rich and then about a year later he called me and I got my sort of chance to play with the band. And I went down to Birdland for the rehearsal. And Mike was doing all these charts that we had worked out together. And Sam was playing a few of the lines. So I went to the rehearsal and I had it all worked out. I had practiced it again, I played all these lines. And it looked like I was reading the music too, because I had the music as a reminder. I remember doing about ten of these things in a row. Complicated stuff, like it would have looked amazing to anybody who thought I was actually doing it. After about ten of them I made a mistake and Buddy dropped the sticks and he says, "Are you with us?" And then he left. He says, "I'll see you tonight."

MR: How big a group was that?

GB: It was just a quintet.

MR: Just a quintet.

GB: Flute, vibes and guitar, bass and drums. And piano. It was a sextet. And you know, Buddy right away became a friend though. He was very nice to me. But it was the best training I had for the Marine Corps, which was coming up, working with Buddy.

MR: Did he ever pull any of his practical jokes on you?

GB: No. I was there when he — we used to have to meet after every set backstage at Birdland. And he would say, "What'd you do that for, the third bar of this—" and, "I told you not to do that before." And, "What was that?" And then we'd have, like a drill instructor you know. But he was difficult on a couple of guys in the band once in a while, and the audience. I remember when there was a guy there making a little noise in front. He said, "Where are you from?" The guy said, "I'm from Pittsburgh." He said, "There's a bus leaving in ten minutes, be under it." And I remember there was a guy there, a younger guy with an older woman you know. And they were talking. And he says, "Hey kid, you always go out with your mother?"

MR: Wow.

GB: But I mean we loved him for that too I guess. He was a very brilliant musician. I mean once he had something, and it was just amazing to watch it to get to — his time feel was so strong, it was just, I don't know any drummer that has quite that impact that he had,

the way he played. And once he learned something, which was right away, no one could play it better.

MR: I was going to say, he must have had an amazing memory because even when he had his big band, he never read music, right?

GB: No he never read music and he was in awe of guys that could read. That's one of the things he really had a lot of respect for me because later on when I saw him when I was doing the Tonight Show, I was actually doing the Tonight Show, I'm not sure when it was, if it was in those days or a little later. And when he ever came as a guest on the show or something like that, he looked at all the guys, with a lot of respect because of that. But no one could do it better than Buddy in terms of like leading a big band. Once he had that music, once he heard the chart and heard how it went, forget it.

MR: What was your first chance to record. Do you remember that?

GB: Well I guess my first, most important thing was when I produced my own record with Mike Moore. I was doing the studio work all the time, I was part of a lot of records. So I saw a web page — not a web page, but one of those Internet — what do you call that stuff?

MR: Website?

GB: I don't know those terms you know. Email. No.

MR: No, I think it's probably a website you saw.

GB: And it had my name and all the records I'd been on. And it was like, it must have been five hundred to a thousand.

MR: You should get a copy of it.

GB: Yeah, I have it at home somewhere.

MR: Great.

GB: But I've done a lot of film dates. In New York when I was — at sort of the tail end of a certain kind of vintage guitar player, there were guys like Tony Mottola and Bucky Pizzarelli, Barry Galbraith, Howie Collins and Al Caiola, Al Cassamentes. And the younger crew like David Spinozza and — oh the guys are going to hate me for forgetting — I worked a lot with a guy named Jay Berliner, Billy — well anyway, Ralph Casales. We were still getting calls for a lot of recordings and film dates. And I did a lot of stuff in the studios. All Burt Bachrach's work, all of Tony Bennett's records, and I was always the young guy on the block and I was that for a while. Particularly with drummers. There was a guy that was on every date. I remember a guy named Dennis — well first there was Bobby Rosengarden. When I first came up he was doing all the work. Then a guy named Bill Lavorgna, who started conducting recently for Liza Minelli. Then there was a guy named Dennis Siewell, who was always on every date. And after that, the last big gun,

there was a guy named Donald McDonald for a while. And the guy — oh he's going to hate me. The guy was from Rochester, he used to play with Chuck—

MR: Steve Gadd.

GB: Steve Gadd was on every date.

MR: Yeah. So when you'd come to the studio for a date, you would not have seen the music beforehand is that right?

GB: Not really, no. A couple of times the contractor knew it was very difficult music. And one time John Williams came to New York to do a movie called — well John Williams came to New York.

MR: Okay.

GB: "Missouri Breaks" it was called. And he had written, the contractor thought, a very difficult part for me and Jay. It was like, you know the country group Flat and Scruggs? One of those real long country solos, in harmony you know. And so he got us the part the night before. And I was really grateful. Because John Williams — yeah I wish I'd even done a better job. John was great though. It really was marvelous.

MR: Can you recall some of your favorite — out of that oh five to one thousand — things that you've played on. Is there any particular events that stand out?

GB: Well I mean the albums with Hubert Laws were great.

MR: Oh yes. Those were great things.

GB: And I always loved the dates with Tony Bennett. Johnny Mandel came in, Roy Burns, Torrie Zito, great conductors, great bands. Sol Gubin or Grady Tate on drums, George Duvivier or Richard Davis or Ron Carter on bass. And the wonderful saxophone sections which were Al Cohn and Zoot Sims and all those great players, and the string sections. The big recording studios. And then my years on the Tonight Show in New York for a couple of years I had to learn — and that trumpet section with Doc Severinsen as the lead trumpet player, Clark Terry and Snooky Young and Jimmy Maxwell. Going to that studio at NBC every day. I shared that show with Tony Mottola for two years.

MR: You guys kind of worked out who was going to do what nights is that right?

GB: Yeah. And during my tenure there for a whole year I did a show called "That Was the Week That Was," for NBC and then occasionally the "Kraft Music Hall." And the rhythm section for Peter Matz and the 'Kraft Music Hall" was Derek Smith, Mel Lewis and Richard Davis and myself. And all the dates with Don Elliott in recording dates on Madison Avenue, it was always Mel Lewis and Richard Davis and myself. And boy I've been through a lot of — you know when you think about just falling into things. And I was a pretty good reader, not a great reader, but I mean I used to be able to cover whatever they wrote. And I guess my interpretation of things was what they liked as well. And then when I started playing the classical guitar I started getting — that was about the

time the Bossa Nova came in. And I was very friendly with Joao Gilberto. He used to borrow my guitar to do concerts. And I learned how to do bossa nova from his records. And I just had barely started to play that way and I got a call from Ahmad Jamal to do a big date on Samba rhythms and I said, "Sure, I'll do it." And when I listen to Joao's record of "Quiet Nights" and then I just took that little bit of information, the basic bossa nova beat, to Rudy VanGelder's studio in New Jersey and it was Richard Evans' big orchestra and Osie Johnson was playing drums and Richard. And it worked out great. I had — I just used to say yes, you know. I just figured, it seemed like you're never called to do things that — you're always called to do things that they know you can do.

MR: Yeah, but you've also risen to the occasion, I can tell.

GB: I think I have you know, but probably because I could, and not even realize it.

MR: Did you prefer a certain kind of guitar work over another? I mean you obviously had to play acoustic, but you also had to play electric.

GB: I really liked it all. I liked it when they wrote a nice line. I just liked when they wrote a line. I had done record dates where there was this big beautiful big band and in the days they used to call three guitar players in and hand you like a rhythm part. And one guy would do [scats], just make a noise. And I can remember spending three hours doing [scats]. And the guys would come up "great, man, you were great. What a great guitar player." And I said oh Jesus. Or play like a little —

MR: [scats] did you have to do those?

GB: Yeah. All that junk. "Fantastic. That Gene, he can do that, man."

MR: What were some of the pop acts that you might have played in the studio with?

GB: Well I guess Burt Bachrach. I would consider him pop music. I mean it was good music in its own way. And he used to really get carried away with whatever little thing I did. "Oh man, you hear what he did there — bing!" Or something like that. And I loved it. And of course it was nice to be appreciated. And I loved a date where I could be creative a little bit and on Burt's dates too, I used to do these classical guitar fills that he liked a lot. And I liked when I had a line to play though, mostly. If it was a film date or the guitar had a melodic line to play, instead of just a lead sheet of some kind.

MR: Did you happen to play on an album with Jackie & Roy called "Time and Love?" Does that ring a bell with you? It was a CTI thing I think.

GB: I did an album with them, but I don't know if that was it. Do you remember the rest of the guys on it?

MR: I can't think of the arranger right now, but I'll come back to it. It's a great record. Wayne Shorter, Charles McPherson, I mean, boy that's a varied list of people and different styles too.

GB: Yeah well you know I think one of the guys that helped me out the most was Ron Carter. I started seeing him on record dates. And he liked what he heard, and Hubert as well. He had, there was a gig — I burped, I'm sorry —

MR: We'll take it out.

GB: And there was a club on the west side called The Guitar. And Ron asked me to do it with him. So it was just me and him in this little club. It was partly owned by Kenny Burrel and all the guys would come down because Ron — Ron honored me by kind of liking what I did, just played tunes together. And I think he recommended me for a lot of things. Right now I'm working for him at City College teaching in his jazz program up there. And what was the question?

MR: The question was talking about Wayne Shorter.

GB: Part of Ron's magic might have gotten into the ears of producers in those days. I know Ron was on the Charles McPherson date and Ron was on the Wayne Shorter date, and they may have asked Ron or somehow the word got around about my playing. And so I remember on Wayne's date, I went in there, and I heard about this mysterious player, this player who played jazz nine 'o nine. You know what I mean? Advanced.

MR: Advanced. Yeah.

GB: I said what am I getting into here? And I go in and I see three percussionists. I think it was Billy Hart, Alphonse Mouzon and then some Italian guy who's name I forget. And there were two bass players I think, Ron and Cecil McBee. And Dave Friedman on vibes. And I forget, it might have been — I don't know who the piano player was. And Wayne starts explaining his charts. He says "I want this to feel like the wind here, and this thing here—" they were sketchy kind of things. And there was enough music to read and react. And I reacted to things and I played and we did one take of things I remember, it was like one or two takes. And the guys would respond. And it came out the album called "Odyssey of Iska." And I got a lot of nice feedback from it. And Wayne called me about a couple of months after the record had been out. He said, "Gene, I love what you did on the CD, so I'm putting this little group together. We're going to do an album and I'm going to rehearse. I would love if you'd be a part of it." And I said, "No," I said, "I've just started my own little duo and I'm really thinking about doing my own personal work." And I wasn't quite that comfortable in the studio, I told him. I said I felt I was just going by the seat of my pants. But I was so glad that he called, and thanked him very much, and I couldn't do it. And what I did was turn down the first Weather Report album.

MR: Is that right?

GB: Yeah. If you notice there wasn't guitar on that.

MR: There was not.

GB: And I didn't say the whole telephone conversation because I thought it would give it away, but he said "I have this bass player Miroslav and Alphonse Mouzon and Joe Zawinul on piano," and he said "we'd love to have you on guitar."

MR: I'll be darned. You finally said no once and it was a —

GB: Well you know I'm not too sure — it wasn't a mistake because I think I could not have resisted the success that that group had. I would have gone out on the road probably and done concerts with them and probably would have delayed my most important work which is getting into the solo work and the duo work with Mike.

MR: Yeah. That's a good story though. Do you still do a lot of studio work, or you've cut back on that?

GB: No, they've cut me out. There's nothing in there. I just booked with one of my favorite arrangers, Jack Courtner. You know I think that so much is done on the computer now.

MR: Right. I was going to ask you if you had—

GB: I did a record date yesterday.

MR: Really?

GB: Two days in a row really. Yesterday was a string quartet of all jazz string players. Violins. And Skitch Henderson was on piano. And Peter Appleyard, and a lady bass player, Nicki Parrott, and Joe Ascione and Bucky Pizzarelli. And it was for label called Arbors Records.

MR: Oh, sure.

GB: And so we did, it was nice to be in the studio. And I was given a lot to play, I mean a lot of jazz playing. Acoustic and electric.

MR: That may be the first like quartet type thing that they've put out. Arbors Records I think.

GB: Maybe. I don't know I'll have to look at the catalogue.

MR: I'm somewhat familiar with that label. That's great.

GB: But I mean there's no studio work.

MR: Not like it used to be.

GB: And if I get a call for studio work it's usually for what I do. It's like to accompany a singer or to maybe play some Brazilian stuff.

MR: What would be your advice to guitar students in colleges these days to prepare themselves for what's available now?

GB: I think the most important thing is to develop your repertoire, learn as many tunes as possible. I think still the standard songs are still what gets you the gigs in life, if you can play. If they know you can play older tunes and if you can improvise and bend with situations and be a nice person. Above all just follow your heart and keep the faith. There is room for everybody in some fashion, as we can see at this convention. There are now seven thousand people here and there are seven thousand more musicians probably this

year looking for work. But everybody's got a smile on their face. You know, try, and success has very little to do with money. It's got a lot to do with your ability to play, and the chance to play. And I would say not to turn down anything because of a lack of — because it didn't pay enough or something like that. Get as many experiences as you can to play. However, there are guys that try to always get you to play for nothing that shouldn't do that either.

MR: There's a certain line—

GB: Don't take that too far, yeah.

MR: Right.

GB: So there are people that can afford to pay a little more money to musicians but they always keep them on that servant level. And that's a shame. But I think there is room for everybody. And follow your heart, follow your blisses, as Joseph Campbell said. And I just had breakfast, as I said, with my roommates, one of my roommates was a pianist in college. And he later went on to be, through the Marine Corps, a pilot for Delta Airlines. And he retired from Delta Airlines and he's now a junior in college studying music. And he's happier than he can ever be. And the other guy is studying bass. He headed the whole Wendy's chain commercials. He did all those commercials. Those are such a nice bunch of commercials for Wendy's. He was in charge of all that for years. And now he's retired. Charlie Rath is his name. And we talked about that music — and they love me because I stayed with it. But I had this other special gift. But here we all are together, we just talk about music.

MR: Well you speak very well of your philosophies about music and life too. I know you've been doing quite a bit of — you do some Eastman work?

GB: Right. Eastman. The New England Conservatory. This year I'm teaching at William Paterson. I took Vic Juris' place, because the king got too busy. I call him "the king." He's a monster. I love the way he plays. He's working with the heavies too, David Liebman and Phil Woods and so, a monster player. So I'm honored to be there for him. And City College with Ron and occasionally Banff, and workshops whenever I can, I love that. I mean if my life was a bunch of what I did yesterday, a workshop and combined with a concert, I'd really love that. Primarily on solo guitar or with a duo. And I love playing with other guys too.

MR: Let me play a piece here off your new CD, if I can find — we had just talked about this too.

[audio interlude]

GB: That's good. Can you hear that? Yeah, leave it right there.

MR: That's nice.

GB: It goes somewhere.

MR: So this is straight acoustic guitar, right?

GB: You know I think we can use any material we want. Keep it going. I just wanted to point out something. You can be inspired by any material. It doesn't have to be hip you know. If you love a piece of music, and I love this song, I loved it in the movie—

MR: Right, me too.

GB: And I like to take tunes like this and change the harmonies. Play it simply and then explore it a little bit.

[audio interlude]

MR: That was beautiful. Very nice.

GB: Now a change of key. That was it.

MR: Oh that is gorgeous. Really nice.

GB: So with a piece of music like that, if there's anybody in the audience that, you know, is maybe turned off by really hard, mainstream jazz playing or stuff like that, and if you can bring them in with something pretty like this, which I love anyway, and most people love it. They may not even admit it you know. But most jazz players love this thing "Hey man your 'Edelweiss' was exquisite." And this is coming from a hot tenor saxophone player, or your "Cavatina" from "The Deer Hunter." That was heaven. Most people love the music. And the one thing I love about the guitar is that you can really do these things, it is a little orchestra. And then you can go from there into something maybe hipper. Bring out the electric guitar and play something hot. Or a Blues. And they're right with you because they fell in love with "Edelweiss."

MR: Right. You've got it covered. What's in the near future for you?

GB: I'm hoping what's in the near future is more of solo concerts and another solo CD. And I know I'm going to do some more work with Michael Moore. We'll always work together a little bit. And some more festivals I hope. I think I'm playing at a festival in Poland next year. And I'm going to North Carolina and do some concerts there coming up. And doing a thing in Ohio, a tribute to Jobim playing a whole evening of his music, which is one of my other CDs that actually as voted one of the top ten CDs in Brazil. Just me and percussion. It's called "Jobim." Someone to light up my life. I had to settle for Jobim. I haven't met her yet. So he's lighting up my life. Pretty good though.

MR: All right. Well it's been great talking with you.

GB: Yeah.

MR: I appreciate your coming.

GB: Monk, it's a pleasure to be here with you.

MR: I think you're going to have a good year, and I hope some of those things come true for you. It's a beautiful piece and I'm sure the rest of the CD holds up to it also.

GB: Oh I think you'll like it, yeah.

MR: All right, thanks for your time.

GB: Thanks, Monk.

MR: Okay.